people was by parading Him four times a year in elaborate *yatra*s (journeys) on land and water, of which the most famous is the *ratha* (chariot)-*yatra*, or chariot procession, in the month of Ashadha, according to the Hindu calendar (roughly mid-June to mid-July in the Gregorian). This is when the idol is wheeled to the temple in an enormous chariot as devotees line the streets in a frenzy, hailing the lord with chants and prayers and craning their necks for a glimpse of the deity seated in the chariot, followed by lesser chariots bearing statues of his brother Balarama and sister Subhadra.

How did the deity transported in this devotional procession become transmogrified into an English term for a relentless, remorseless, unstoppable force that destroys anything in its path? Orientalism began early, alas: four centuries before the British conquest of India, fantastical tales about India were propagated in the fourteenth-century travelogue of Sir John Mandeville, who described the festival in his *Travels* and depicted Hindus throwing themselves under the wheels of the enormous Jagannath chariots as a religious sacrifice and being crushed to death. Hinduism, in fact, has no concept of such human sacrifice; if Sir John really saw a Hindu killed under the wheels of a chariot, it can only be because a poor devotee stumbled and fell accidentally upon the path in the tumult and the enormous chariot could not easily stop or turn on the narrow road. Still, the tale, the false image of the faith it portrayed, and the unfortunate associations of the word persisted. By the eighteenth century 'juggernaut' was in common use as a synonym for an irresistible and destructive force that demands total devotion or unforgiving sacrifice—the sense in which it pops up in the novels of Charlotte Brontë and Charles Dickens, and even Robert Louis Stevenson, who applied it to Dr Jekyll's foil, Mr Hyde. It was only Mark Twain, in his *Autobiography*, who described Juggernaut as the kindest of gods; and a look at the lovely model of an eighteenth-century ratha in the British Museum's collection shows you why, for such an exquisite piece of art would only have been used to transport a figure of reverence, not of fear. But alas, by then the damage had been done.

But I digress. Hinduism did not stop with the absorption of earlier animist or tribal religions. It accepted the precepts of Mahavira, the